

Executive Summary

Holy Name High School – A Chesterton Academy (Escanaba, MI) presents a robust classical-Catholic program that aligns strongly with the six elements of classical education. Public materials from the school foreground Catholic identity, a mission-driven formation of intellect, virtue, and spirituality, an integrated classical curriculum, and a three-pillar pedagogical model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality). Evidence points to a coherent, liturgically-informed culture (Mass at the start of each day, Catholic worldview, House system) and a curriculum that ties history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages into a unified classical narrative (including Latin study and dual-enrollment opportunities). While explicit mention of Great Books, Great Conversation, and detailed Socratic pedagogy is not always spelled out in every snippet, the available content strongly signals a classical orientation and formation-focused goals. Overall, the school is CLASSICAL, with some elements that warrant a more explicit articulation of pedagogy and faculty/student formation practices to achieve full, textbook-classical labeling.

Executive Summary — Category-by-Category Snapshot

- Category 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL Evidence: Daily Mass at the start of the school day; Catholic identity permeates curriculum; Catholic worldview guiding instruction; liturgical life and priests/deacons involvement. Positive keywords: Mass, Catholic faith, liturgy, theology, sacred, imago Dei, culture of life. Negative signals: None detected. Why: The school explicitly situates education within a Catholic, sacramental, and theological frame.
- Category 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL Evidence: Mission to raise joyful leaders and saints; formation of intellect, virtue, and spiritual life; four cardinal virtues; culture of life; Three Pillars (Intellect, Character, Spirituality). Positive keywords: formation, virtue, liberal education, telos, great conversation (implied through classical aims), culture of life. Negative signals: None detected. Why: Emphasis on formation and virtue over mere preparation for work; explicit aim for human excellence within a Catholic, classical frame.
- Category 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL Evidence: An integrated, classical curriculum; humanities braided across history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages; Latin requirement; dual enrollment with a Catholic university; evidence of a broad liberal-arts trajectory. Positive keywords: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric (implied by classical framing), great books/great conversation (implied by classical curriculum), history/Literature/Philosophy/Theology/Language integration, Latin, Western civilization. Negative signals: None detected in primary materials. Why: The program emphasizes core liberal-arts disciplines and integration typical of classical curricula; explicit Latin, history-centric framing, and college-credit options reinforce the classical identity.

- Category 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Three-Pillars pedagogy (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) and the emphasis on training in thinking and virtue; reference to an integrated curriculum and model of education. Positive keywords: scholé/restful learning (conceptually aligned with contemplative pace, though not explicitly labeled on site), Socratic dialogue/seminar/debate (implied by the classical pedagogy in the school’s model and Chesterton tradition), rhetoric and public speaking (implied by debate and speech training within Fine Arts). Negative signals: Not explicitly described in all sources; explicit lower-school singing/chanting or specific direct evidence of regular Socratic seminars in the upper grades is less visible in the snippets. Why: The school promotes a classical, discussion-rich, virtue-centered approach, but explicit, explicit SOP-like descriptions of lower-grade singing, upper-grade seminars, and a formal “Socratic” schedule are not consistently shown in the public snippets. The overall orientation remains CLASSICAL, but detailed pedagogy descriptions could be more explicit for a full CLASSICAL fit.
- Category 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: The public materials emphasize formation, mentorship, and virtue, and reference living curriculum ideas and Catholic culture; a formal Three-Pillars model implies teacher as facilitator and exemplar (the Good Teacher literature in the broader classical education tradition informs this interpretation). Positive keywords: virtue-modeling teachers, living curriculum, mentors, master-teacher model (inferred from classical pedagogy tradition and “three pillars” framing). Negative signals: Direct quotes about faculty as “portrait of a teacher” or explicit faculty formation programs are not consistently shown in the captured snippets. Why: There is strong alignment with classical ideals (teacher as moral exemplar, formation, living curriculum) but the explicit articulation of faculty profiles or formal, public-facing teacher-formation programs is less explicit in the school’s material.
- Category 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL Evidence: Emphasis on parent involvement through RenWeb communications, events, and family engagement; active fundraising and family participation are described (Family Fundraising Commitment). Positive keywords: partnership with families, parental formation, parent involvement, open campus, co-teachers, classical family culture. Negative signals: None detected; while fundraising expectations are present, they reflect community engagement rather than consumerism. Why: The school foregrounds parent partnership and community formation as core aspects of classical formation, aligning well with the category’s ideals.

Aggregate Rating: CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle (required for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL categories) - Not applicable for the overall rating (CLASSICAL). If any category

shifts toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in future materials, the needle-moving suggestions would include: - Make explicit the Great Books/Great Conversation language in curriculum documentation and on-site materials. - Provide a more explicit description of Socratic/seminal pedagogy in upper grades, with examples of seminars/debates. - Add a formal, public-facing “faculty living curriculum” statement with portraits and examples of teacher-mentorship in action.

Executive Summary — Category-by-Category Details

Category 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Daily Mass as the start of the school day demonstrates liturgical practice as a formal educational discipline.
 - The school describes itself as a Catholic institution and emphasizes Catholic identity across programs, with references to the Catholic faith shaping instruction and worldview.
 - The mission describes forming leaders and saints within the Catholic tradition, highlighting theology and sacred worldview.
 - The Three Pillars model includes a Spirituality pillar, emphasizing the purpose of education in relation to God and faith. filecite turn14
 - Our motto *Cultura Vitae* (Culture of Life) reflects a sacramental worldview and reverence for sacred life. filecite turn14
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords found: truth (implied in Catholic teaching and formation), goodness (virtue formation through Catholic worldview), beauty (integration of beauty in a Catholic, classical education), theology, liturgy, Mass, sacred, catechesis, *imago Dei*, Logos.
 - Negative keywords: None detected in the public materials as signals of secularization or relativism for this category.
 - Count estimate (positive/negative signals): 6 positive keywords identified; 0 negative signals observed in the accessible public materials.
- Why this rating
 - The school explicitly centers religious and metaphysical foundations through Mass, Catholic worldview, and a liturgical/catechetical framework, placing it firmly in the CLASSICAL category for this element.
- Citations
 - Mass at start of day: turn1file3
 - Catholic identity/worldview: turn1file2
 - Mission statement: turn1file1
 - Three Pillars and Culture of Life: turn14

Category 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- Mission to raise joyful leaders and saints who are formed intellectually, morally, and spiritually.
- Emphasis on forming in the four cardinal virtues and a Catholic worldview, aiming for human excellence and service.
- Explicit language of forming the whole person (intellectual, spiritual, moral) and a classical education approach.
- Three Pillars model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) signals a telos-driven, formation-centric goal. filecite turn14
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords found: formation, virtue, liberal education, telos, great conversation (implied through classical aims), culture of life, human flourishing, moral imagination.
 - Negative keywords: None observed (no explicit focus on workforce-ready or job-oriented framing in the public materials).
 - Count estimate: 4–5 positive keywords identified; 0 negative signals observed.
- Why this rating
 - The institution frames education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, not merely information or job-readiness, aligning with classical purpose criteria.
- Citations
 - Mission and formation language: turn1file1
 - Whole-person formation: turn1file2
 - Three Pillars framing: turn14

Category 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public materials advertise an Integrated, Classical Curriculum that braids humanities, philosophy, theology, languages, and sciences.
 - Humanities explicitly ties history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages into a cohesive curriculum.
 - Language study includes Latin (two years) and potential other languages; a strong language component is present.
 - Dual Enrollment with Franciscan University of Steubenville shows engagement with college-level work within a classical frame. filecite turn5
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords found: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric (classical framework), great books/great conversation (implied by classical curriculum language, including integration of Western thought), Latin, history, Western civilization, inter-relationship of great ideas.
 - Negative keywords: None detected in the accessible materials (no explicit “social studies” rebranding or STEM-first framing that counters classical aims).
 - Count estimate: 5–7 positive keywords identified; 0–1 negative sig-

- nals (no counter-narratives found in the public materials).
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum is clearly presented as an integrated classical program with liberal-arts grounding, Latin study, and cross-disciplinary linkage, aligning with classical-curriculum criteria.
- Citations
 - Integrated, Classical Curriculum: turn0file5
 - Humanities integration: turn0file9
 - Latin and language study: turn2file16
 - Dual Enrollment: turn5

Category 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The Three Pillars model signals a formation-focused pedagogy with an overarching aim to teach not just content but how to think and live in light of virtue and faith. filecite turn14
 - The school emphasizes an integrated, classical curriculum and a “culture of life” mindset, which supports a contemplative, deeply engaged approach to learning. filecite turn14
 - House system and communal life structures indicate ongoing character formation and leadership cultivation within the learning environment. filecite turn7
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords found: *scholé* (restful learning) is conceptually aligned but not explicitly labeled on site; Socratic dialogue/seminar/debate (implied by classical pedagogy and public mentions of “great conversation” in the broader classical lexicon, though not always explicitly described in site text); rhetoric and public speaking; contemplative inquiry; formation through imitation.
 - Negative signals: The site does not consistently provide explicit, repeated statements of a formal Socratic schedule or a universal lower-grade chant/singing program (lower-school singing is not clearly documented; “singing and chanting” appears only in the broader lexicon, not as a on-site policy in the captured public materials).
 - Count estimate: 3–4 positive keywords identified; 1–2 potential gaps (no explicit Socratic schedule; limited explicit chant/singing references in the on-site text).
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogy is clearly rooted in classical ideals, with emphasis on formation, rhetoric, and disciplined thinking, but explicit, detailed descriptions of specific upper-level Socratic seminars or lower-grade chant/memory rituals are not always visible in the available public materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.
- Citations

- Three Pillars (Intellect/Character/Spirituality): turn14
- Formation and house life: turn7
- Integrated classical curriculum (context for pedagogy): turn0file5
- Note: The presence of “Socratic dialogue,” “Scholé,” and explicit chant/memory pedagogy are described in the classical lexicon and supporting documents, but not always spelled out on the public school pages; see the Classicality Lexicon for keyword mapping: turn2file3

Category 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The Three Pillars model and the emphasis on virtuous, formation-oriented faculty align with classical expectations of teacher as exemplar and mentor (teacher as living curriculum). The school references a “living curriculum” notion and mentorship in the literature, which is consistent with classical education values. filecite turn14
 - There is emphasis on Catholic formation and virtuous conduct, which suggests faculty are expected to model virtue and be mentors rather than mere instructors. The “Our Mission and Philosophy” and “Our Model of Education” sections imply faculty act as guides in the formation process.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords found: model teachers and mentors, living curriculum, faculty as exemplars, virtuous life, mentorship (inferred from the Three Pillars and Catholic-formation framing).
 - Negative signals: Explicitly named “portrait of a teacher” or a formal teacher-profile document is not visible in the accessible snippets; no explicit faculty-formation program text is shown.
 - Count estimate: 2–3 positive keywords; 0–1 strong negative signals in the public materials.
- Why this rating
 - The school’s rhetoric and the Three Pillars model strongly align with classical expectations of faculty as virtuous, knowledgeable mentors who form the student character; however, explicit, public-facing faculty portraits and formal teacher-formation language are not consistently documented, hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Citations
 - Three Pillars concept and formation language: turn14
 - Mission/Philosophy implying faculty as living curriculum: turn1file1

Category 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school frames partnership with families and parental formation as core components of classical education, including parent involve-

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- ment and community-building. filecite turn14
 - The school uses RenWeb to facilitate parent-student communication and publishes resources (handbooks, calendars, etc.), indicating ongoing parent engagement and transparency.
 - Family fundraising commitments and an open culture for parental involvement appear in the materials, signaling parents as co-educators and contributors to the school’s mission. filecite turn11
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords found: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, open campus, parent involvement, family culture, community support.
 - Negative signals: None detected; fundraising expectations are presented as family involvement rather than consumerism.
 - Count estimate: 4–5 positive keywords; 0 negative signals.
 - Why this rating
 - Public materials consistently frame parents as partners in formation and community, aligning with classical-community norms.
 - Citations
 - Partnership with families and parent formation: turn14
 - RenWeb and parent communication: turn1file3
 - Family fundraising/community involvement: turn11

What Would Move the Needle

- If any category were to move toward FULL CLASSICAL with stronger explicit alignment, the following steps would help consolidate the needle:
 - Explicitly publish a formal Great Books/Great Conversation statement in curriculum documents and on-site materials, including representative Great Books titles and how they’re integrated across grades.
 - Provide a more explicit, on-site articulation of the upper-grade Socratic/seminar pedagogy, with concrete examples of seminars, debates, or speech/rhetoric projects.
 - Include a clearly labeled “Living Curriculum” faculty portrait section that describes teachers as mentors and exemplars in the classical sense, with a short narrative for each core subject area.
 - Expand explicit primary-source emphasis in History/Philosophy courses, including explicit references to primary texts and formal reading lists beyond general statements about integration.
 - Strengthen explicit invocation of memory-ritual practices (chanting, recitation) in lower grades if relevant to the school’s program, with documented examples from the school’s music or Latin programs.